by something within that keeps you going. India arrive with realistic intentions of winning in England for the first time in many years and, as our orbits circle each other, there are moments before the series where our paths cross.

I am with Felix and Greg recording a *Tailenders* episode on the outfield at Lord's and we walk past him. On meeting Kohli's eyes, the other Tailenders pause to acknowledge the change in my tone – the way we unflinchingly look at each other, like boxers before a fight, our first blows thrown before we even get in the ring.

It's the first Test at Edgbaston and I am at the top of my mark, our eyes meeting again as he turns to face the next ball. I know that the ball is moving and just as I had found that extra level when first bowling to Kohli's predecessor, Tendulkar, all those years ago, I breathe at my mark, feel the seam on my fingers and run in to bowl. There is a heightened concentration and intensity today, as if me vs Kohli is not just a part of England vs India, but a separate battle in its own universe.

I am getting the ball to swing at ease, teasing him with deliveries outside his off stump. He is determined to leave the ball there, fighting within himself to not do what he did last tour and leave his bat hanging outside the off stump and edge behind. A few whistle past the off stump. I try to drag him across the stumps, every ball landing exactly where I want it to, before the odd one very rarely just comes into his pads. One falls just short of the diving hands of Jos Buttler at fourth slip. He edges another but does so with soft hands, falling just short of Jonny Bairstow. He's not scoring any runs – but runs are not on the agenda. It's about his survival and my hunting. That is the battle. He edges again, falling just short of Keaton Jennings.

Every ball is met with a silence beforehand and then followed by a sigh or a gasp from the slip cordon as Kohli hangs on. The exact sequence plays out over after over, tiny variations on a theme, both of our temperaments and discipline being tested. I finally get a genuine edge and as I go up to celebrate, Jennings dives in front of Dawid Malan at second slip, blinding his view for a second, and the ball spills out of Malan's hands. It's a reprieve. Kohli has survived. He goes on to score 149, his first century in England, expanding after getting through the initial arm wrestle between us. It's one of the times I don't get the better of him in England, but the other